

Chapter-4

Formal Letters

Formal letters, also known as official letters, are the letters written to the head of an institution for a particular purpose. The language, style and tone of formal letters are formal and polite with no personal references, opinions or expression. Although there is no specified word limit for a formal letter, it should stick to the point and justify the purpose of writing the letter. The content should be well organized in a logical sequence using appropriate cohesive devices.

Types of Formal Letters

- ⇒ Application to Principal/Class in charge/Librarian/Head of the Department/ etc.
- ⇒ Job Applications
- ⇒ Letters to the Head of a particular department/ organisation
- ⇒ Letters to CEO/Bank Manager/Director
- ⇒ Letters to Publishers
- ⇒ Complaints
- ⇒ Letters to the editor
- ⇒ Business Letters (Order/cancel/replace a product)

Constituents of a Formal Letter

1. **Sender's Address:** It is written at the top left corner of the letter. It includes:
 - ⇒ House/flat/shop/ number
 - ⇒ Name of building in case of flat
 - ⇒ Name/number of street
 - ⇒ Name of sector/colony, one can also include a landmark such as opposite SBI Branch or Near Orbit Mall etc.
 - ⇒ Name of village/town/city
 - ⇒ Pin code
 - ⇒ State
 - ⇒ Country (if the letter is written to a person staying in some other country)

Important Note: Sender's Address is not required when a student writes an application to the Principal, Class in charge, Head of the Department or Librarian of his/her school.

2. **Date:** It is written below the sender's address. In Applications to the Principal, it is written below the receiver's address. There are many formats of writing a date. The name of the month should be written complete. Study carefully the formats of date given below.
 - ⇒ D/M/Y: 24th November, 20XX or 24 November, 20XX
 - ⇒ M/D/Y: November 24, 20XX
3. **Receiver's Address:** Receiver's Address is written in a particular sequence. It includes:
 - ⇒ The Formal Designation
 - ⇒ The name of the School/Department/Organisation/Publishing House etc.
 - ⇒ Complete Address of the School/Department/Organisation/Publishing House etc.

Study carefully the samples of receiver's address given in the table below.

Letter/Application to Principal	The Principal St. Andrew Convent School Sector 32 Chandigarh
Letter to the Head of an Organisation	The Health Officer Municipal Corporation Jalandhar
	The Post Master General Post Office Model Town Ludhiana
	The Senior Superintendent of Police SSP Office Amritsar

4. Subject or Heading: It briefly states the purpose of writing the letter. It is generally highlighted or underlined.

Examples:

- ✦ Subject: Application for School Leaving Certificate
- ✦ Subject: Complaint against the Postman
- ✦ Subject: Frequent power failures
- ✦ Subject: Bad quality and insufficient supply of water

5. Salutation: Salutation is the formal and polite way we address the recipient of the letter. It is written below the subject. Example: Dear Sir/Madam, Dear Sirs, or only Sir/Madam

6. Body of the letter: It is the main part of the letter which contains the message or the information meant to be conveyed through the letter. Although there is no hard and fast rule regarding the number of paragraphs it should contain, it is usually written in three or four paragraphs depending on the content to be written. The body has three parts:

(a) Introduction: It includes the introduction of the sender and purpose of writing the letter.

(b) Main Message: The second paragraph is the main message or information to be conveyed. It gives a detailed description of the purpose of writing the letter. This part should be well organized using appropriate cohesive devices. If the content of the letter is long, there may be two paragraphs for the main message.

(c) Closure: The third paragraph concludes the letter. It usually states what is expected of the receiver. It may also include some suggestions related to the purpose of the letter. It also includes a complimentary closure such as 'Thank you' or 'Thanking you in anticipation'.

7. Subscription: It is a polite way of closing the letter. Read the examples of subscription given below.

✦ **For Principal**

- Yours obediently

✦ **For others**

- Yours faithfully/truly

8. Signature: The sender's signature is written just below the subscription

Application to the Principal Purpose

- ✦ To apply for a Leave
- ✦ To seek Permission
- ✦ To Seek Admission
- ✦ To apply for School-Leaving Certificate
- ✦ To request for exemption from fee/exam/test
- ✦ To request for fee Concession
- ✦ To get issued a certificate
- ✦ To get re-issued an I-Card/School Fee Booklet/ Library Card etc
- ✦ To request for change of class/section
- ✦ To report an issue and seek solution to the problem
- ✦ To apologize

Format of Application to Principal

Receiver's Address

Date of writing the letter

Subject:

Salutation

Introduction: Name, Class, Section, Roll Number, Purpose of writing the letter

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Main message: Details of the issue the application is about, details in terms of cause, effect, result etc.

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Closure: Request for required action/permission/enquiry/ issuance/change etc.

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Complimentary Closure: Thanking you in anticipation

Subscription

Signature

Roll No

Class, Section/Designation

Application to Principal -Sample

You are Akriti Singla of Grade VI A of Strawberry Fields Public School, Pune. Write a letter to your Principal requesting him/her to exempt you from taking Office Tests as you have to go to Mumbai to perform in the Theatre Round of Indian Idol, a reality show telecast on Sony TV.

The Principal
Strawberry Fields Public School
Pune
July 27, 20XX

Subject: Request for exemption from Office Tests

My name is Akriti Singla, and I am a student of grade VI A in your school. My roll number is 7.

I feel greatly excited and proud to inform you that I have cleared the Audition Round of the popular singing reality show 'Indian Idol' telecast on Sony TV, and got selected for the Theatre Round. The shooting of the Theatre Round of the same will be held from August 5 to August 10, 20XX in Mumbai. The dates of Office Tests scheduled for grade VI coincide with the dates of the Theatre Round.

You are humbly requested to exempt me from appearing in the above mentioned Office Tests. I will be highly obliged to you.

Thank you.

Yours obediently
Akriti Singla
Roll No. 7
Grade VI A

[illegible]

This image shows a full page of white paper with horizontal dotted lines, resembling notebook paper. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There is no handwriting or other markings on the paper.

3. You are the captain of the hockey team of your school. Write an application to your Principal requesting him/her to order for some new hockey sticks as the old ones are in bad state and insufficient in number.



Hints: Introduce yourself, describe the state of hockey sticks, request for ordering new ones, explain how the new ones will be beneficial, mention some upcoming hockey event

[illegible]

Format of a Formal Letter

Sender's Address

Date of writing the letter

Receiver's Address

Subject:

Salutation

Introduction: Introduction, Purpose of writing

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Main message: Details of the issue, supporting sentences, cause, effect, suggestions etc.

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.....

Closure: Conclusion, request, proposal or offer

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.....
.....

Complimentary Closure

Subscription
Signature

Formal Letter-Sample

House No. 315, Street No. 5
New Azaad Colony
Moga
October 25, 20XX

The President
Municipal Committee
Moga

Subject: Regarding insanitary conditions of the locality

Sir

I am a resident of New Azaad Colony. Through this letter of mine, I wish to draw your kind attention towards the insanitary conditions prevailing in our locality.

Our colony, though located in the heart of the city, is the most neglected and worst maintained colony in the town. There are no sweepers to clean the streets. There are no provisions for throwing the garbage. Consequently, the heaps of garbage are scattered here and there spreading foul odours in all directions. These heaps are the breeding places for flies and mosquitoes. The sewage system of the colony is in a bad state. There are cracked drainage pipes and overflowing manholes making the streets dirty and stinking. The dirty water leaking all the time is a great threat for the health of the residents of the colony.

This state of affairs needs your urgent attention and the needful action before epidemics like malaria and cholera break out. You are humbly requested to look into the matter and do the needful.

Thanking you in anticipation

Yours truly
Dheeraj Yadav

1. Write a letter to the Senior Superintendent of Police of your town showing your concern about the increasing incidents of thefts and snatching in your town and requesting him to do the needful.



Hints: Introduce yourself, draw attention towards the issue, report a few incidents, , request to do the needful, make suggestions

[illegible]

2. Write a letter to the SDO of Punjab State Electricity Board complaining against the unplanned and frequent power cuts in your locality.



Hints: Introduce yourself, draw attention towards the issue, mention frequent electric faults, explain effects on people, request to do the needful

[illegible]

[illegible]